As the platform grew, the role of authorization grew as well. Access decisions were no longer limited to simple role checks at the edge of an application. They increasingly depended on relationships, attributes, and real-time context, and were evaluated as part of how systems operated. What had once been a localized concern began to shape behavior across services, teams, and customer interactions.

What they did not initially realize was how crucial authorization would become to the company's future or how costly it would be to let decision logic evolve in isolation across teams and systems. Authorization was more than a feature of the platform. It had become part of ACME's operating model. And the drawbacks of a piecemeal approach were starting to impact revenue, reputation, and the company's ability to scale.

This realization did not come all at once but developed gradually, as leaders across engineering, security, and the business started to notice recurring decision patterns everywhere. Choices about who or what could act were shaping product design, partnership strategy, and risk posture. The infrastructure supporting those decisions had grown incrementally, but its significance had increased more quickly.

By the time ACME recognized authorization as a strategic concern, it had already taken many steps to manage it effectively. What changed wasn't their commitment to improving access control, but their understanding that authorization was not just something to implement well; it had become something the organization had to design and rely upon to scale.

19.1 When authorization became the hard problem

Initially, the issues seemed unrelated. A product launch slipped because partner access rules behaved differently across environments. A major customer raised concerns about inconsistent permission failures during a critical deployment. Engineering teams spent weeks resolving policy differences between services that had developed independently. Security reviews revealed delegation paths that were technically correct but hard to understand. Each incident was investigated, addressed, and eventually closed.